

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

WEDNESDAY, FEBRUARY 4, 2026

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

US House sets stage for debate on ICE

President signs off on funding bill to end partial closure

By Kevin Freking
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump signed a roughly \$1.2 trillion government funding bill Tuesday that ends the partial federal shutdown that began over the weekend and sets the stage for an intense debate in Congress over Homeland Security funding.

The president moved quickly to sign the bill after the House approved it with a 217-214 vote.

The vote wrapped up work on 11 of the 12 annual appropriations bills, funding the vast majority of the government for the budget year ending Sept. 30.

The last bill still to be worked out covers the Department of Homeland Security, where Democrats are demanding more restrictions on immigration enforcement operations.

Passage of the legislation marked the end point for one funding fight, but the start of another. That's because the package only funds the Department of Homeland Security for two weeks, through Feb 13, at the behest of Democrats who are demanding the restrictions after the shooting deaths of Alex Pretti and Renee Good by federal officers in Minneapolis.

Difficult negotiations are ahead, particularly for the agency that enforces the nation's immigration laws — U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement, or ICE.

House Democratic Leader Hakeem Jeffries quickly warned that Democrats would not support any further temporary funding for Homeland Security without substantial changes to its immigration operations, raising the potential of another shutdown for the department and its agencies.

"We need dramatic change in order to make sure that ICE and

Turn to Bills, Page 4



Marimar Martinez, who was shot five times by immigration enforcement agents in Chicago, testifies during a public forum on the violent use of force by Department of Homeland Security agents on Tuesday in Washington. AARON SCHWARTZ/GETTY

'It seemed like time stopped'

Marimar Martinez recounts shooting by immigration agent at Washington forum

By Jason Meisner
and Caroline Kubzansky
Chicago Tribune

When Marimar Martinez noticed a carload of U.S. Customs and Border Protection agents driving through Chicago last fall at the height of Operation Midway Blitz, she thought she had little to fear from following them.

While testifying at a public forum on the actions of immigration agents in Washington on Tuesday, Martinez, 30 and a U.S. citizen from a family of Mexican immigrants, recalled how as she turned onto South Kedzie Avenue in Brighton Park, the federal vehicle she'd been tail-

ing swerved into the side of her car. She froze and slammed her brakes. The agent who had been driving got out of his car.

"It seemed like time stopped," she said.

What happened next has been detailed in reams of court hearings, interviews and news stories: Agent Charles Exum fired five shots, striking Martinez in the arms, legs and chest. Then he bragged about it in a group text to other agents: "I fired five rounds and she had seven holes. Put that in your book, boys."

Martinez was initially charged with "ramming" and assaulting a federal agent, but the government dropped the case against her and a co-defendant, Anthony

Ruiz, just 15 days after Exum's admissions.

Martinez's testimony at Tuesday's meeting, not a full-blown congressional hearing but a forum organized in response to recent violence against U.S. citizens in Minneapolis, including the fatal shootings of Renee Good and Alex Pretti, comes after weeks of blowback against the immigration enforcement raids that have rattled cities like Chicago.

That response triggered a brief, partial government shutdown that ended Tuesday as Capitol Hill girds itself for a longer fight over funding for the U.S. Department of Homeland Security, which Democrats have pledged

to oppose until officials put more restrictions on immigration enforcement operations.

Martinez on Tuesday echoed those demands to curb the raids and said she was doing so in part because she saw herself as a voice for others who did not survive their encounters with federal agents. Good's brothers and Chicago attorney Antonio Romanucci, who is representing the Good family, spoke to the forum moments before Martinez did.

"I am Renee Good, I am Alex Pretti, I am Silverio Villegas Gonzalez, I am Keith Porter," she said. "This needs to stop now."

Turn to Forum, Page 9



Paul Botts, president and executive director of the Wetland Initiative, looks out on the landscape on Monday at Harborside Marsh Pond on Chicago's Far South Side. The wetlands alongside a golf course, frozen in the winter, will be restored after past industrial use. BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Illinois first to recognize rewilding

Law allows state to pursue projects that restore land to its natural state

By Christiana Freitag
Chicago Tribune

As sweeping changes to the federal Clean Water Act in recent years have weakened protections for wetlands, Illinois has become the first state in the nation to officially recognize a conservation tactic known as rewilding.

The Illinois Rewilding Law, which took effect last month, empowers the Illinois Department of Natural Resources to

pursue projects that restore land to its natural state, said Illinois Rep. Anna Moeller, an Elgin Democrat and primary sponsor of the bill.

The law could encompass the reintroduction of keystone species that improve ecosystems, like beavers and bison. But officials and environmentalists say closing the federal gaps in wetland protection is their focus right now. Largely symbolic, the Rewilding Law is the first step toward enacting legislation with

permitting powers, they say.

"Wetlands are hugely important for our water quality, for preventing flooding, for helping native species that are endemic to those areas," Moeller said. "Once we lose them, they're gone forever."

In 2023, the U.S. Supreme Court curtailed federal wetland protections in Sackett v. EPA, limiting federal Clean Water Act protections to only wetlands

Turn to Rewilding, Page 5

Schools, public housing, transit remain rudderless

Under Johnson, agencies without permanent leaders for at least a year

By Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

Chicago's schools, its train and bus system and its public housing agency have all been without permanent leaders for at least a year now under Mayor Brandon Johnson, complicating their mission to deliver essential services without someone setting clear goals and funding priorities at the top.

As Johnson is about to reach the three-year mark in his first term, he has not named heads of the Chicago Public Schools, Chicago Housing Authority or Chicago Transit Authority, amid political challenges and sea changes in governance structures.

It has been several mayoral administrations since these jobs leading among the most powerful and important public agencies in the city have been vacant at the

same time for so long. Personnel appointments have proven some of the mayor's most difficult issues as he's transitioned from a fire-brand union organizer to a chief executive tasked with selecting trustworthy people to advance his progressive agenda.

Johnson said last week he intends to change that "as soon as we find individuals that fit the mold."

"The interim process does not prevent us from executing government," he said when pressed on his timeline at a City Hall news conference. "It's not indicative of whether or not we can continue to accomplish our goals. It just shows you how thorough I am."

The CTA's last president, Dorval Carter, resigned at the end of January 2025. Ex-CPS CEO Pedro Martinez was fired in December 2024, though he stayed on as a lame-duck schools chief for six months. And the CHA's CEO spot has been vacant since Tracey Scott stepped down in October 2024.

Turn to Agencies, Page 4

INSIDE



Bulls take aggressive approach

After years of muted activity at midseason, the Bulls kick off flurry of trade deadline activity with Nikola Vučević, left, and Jaden Ivey trades. **Chicago Sports**

A CHICAGO LEGEND: Gus Rickette, of Uncle Remus Saucy Fried Chicken in the city's Austin neighborhood, turns 100 this year. **Food & Health**

